

'Patience! yes, until that brave gentleman is roasted—is that what you mean?' And D'Arragnan rushed forward.

'Remain where you are, sir,' said Monk, in a tone of command. And he advanced towards the house, just as an officer had approached it, saying to the besieged: 'The house is burning, you will be roasted within an hour! There is still time—come, tell us what you know of General Monk, and we will spare your life. Reply, or by Saint Patrick—'

The besieged made no answer; he was no doubt reloading his pistol.

'A reinforcement is expected,' continued the officer; 'in a quarter of an hour there will be a hundred men around your house.'

'I reply to you,' said the Frenchman. 'Let your men be sent away; I will come out freely and repair to the camp alone, or else I will be killed here!'

'Mille tonnerres!' shouted D'Arragnan; 'why, that's the voice of Athos! Ah canailles!' and the sword of D'Arragnan flashed from its sheath. Monk stopped him and advanced himself, exclaiming, in a sonorous voice: 'Hô! what is going on here? Digby, whence this fire? why these cries?'

'The general!' cried Digby, letting the point of his sword fall.

'The general!' repeated the soldiers.

'Well, what is there so astonishing in that?' said Monk, in a calm tone. Then, silence being re-established,—'Now,' said he, 'who lit this fire?'

The soldiers hung their heads.

'What! do I ask a question, and nobody answers me?' said Monk. 'What! do I find a fault, and nobody repairs it? The fire is still burning, I believe.'

Immediately the twenty men rushed forward, seizing pails, buckets, jars, barrels, and extinguishing the fire with as much ardour as they had, an instant before, employed in promoting it. But already, and before all the rest, D'Arragnan had applied a ladder to the house, crying, 'Athos! it is I, D'Arragnan! Do not kill me, my dearest friend!' And in a moment the count was clapped in his arms. In the meantime, Grimaud, preserving his calmness, dismantled the fortification of the ground-floor, and after having opened the door, stood, with his arms folded, quietly on the sill. Only, on hearing the voice of D'Arragnan, he uttered an exclamation of surprise. The fire being extinguished, the soldiers presented themselves, Digby at their head.

'General,' said he, 'excuse us, what we have done was for love of your honour, whom we thought lost.'

'You are mad, gentlemen. Lost! Is a man like me to be lost? Am I not permitted to be absent, according to my pleasure, without giving formal notice? Do you, by chance, take me for a citizen from the city? Is a gentleman, my friend, my guest, to be besieged, entrapped, and threatened with death, because he is suspected? What signifies the word, suspected? Curse me if I don't have every one of you shot like dogs, that the brave gentleman has left alive!'

'General,' said Digby, pitcously, 'there were twenty-eight of us, and see, there are eight on the ground.'

'I authorize M. le Comte de la Fère to send the twenty to join the eight,' said Monk, stretching out his hand to Athos. 'Let them return to camp. Mr. Digby, you will consider yourself under arrest for a month.'

'General—'

'That is to teach you, sir, not to act, another time, without orders.'

'I had those of the lieutenant, general.'

'The lieutenant had no such orders to give you, and he shall be placed under arrest, instead of you, if he has really commanded you to burn this gentleman.'

'He did not command that, general; he commanded us to bring him to the camp; but the count was not willing to follow us.'

'I was not willing that they should enter and plunder my house,' said Athos to Monk, with a significant look.

'And you were quite right. To the camp, I say.' The soldiers departed with dejected looks. 'Now we are alone,' said Monk to Athos, 'have the goodness to tell me, monsieur, why you persisted in remaining here, whilst you had your felucca—'

'I waited for you, general,' said Athos. 'Had not your honour appointed to meet me in a week?'

An eloquent look from D'Arragnan made it clear to Monk that these two men, so brave and so loyal, had not acted in concert for his abduction. He knew already it could not be so.

'Monsieur,' said he to D'Arragnan, 'you were perfectly right. Have the kindness to allow me a moment's conversation with M. le Comte de la Fère?' D'Arragnan took advantage of this to go and ask Grimaud how he was. Monk requested Athos to conduct him to the chamber he lived in.

This chamber was still full of smoke and rubbish. More than fifty balls had passed through the windows and mutilated the walls. They found a table, inkstand, and materials for writing. Monk took up a pen, wrote a single line, signed it, folded the paper, sealed the letter with the seal of his ring, and handed over the missive to Athos, saying, 'Monsieur, carry, if you please, this letter to King Charles II, and set out immediately, if nothing detains you here any longer.'

'And the casks?' said Athos.

'The fisherman who brought me hither will assist you in transporting them on board. Depart, if possible, within an hour.'

'Yes, general,' said Athos.

'Monsieur D'Arragnan!' cried Monk, from the window. D'Arragnan ran up precipitately.

'Embrace your friend and bid him adieu, sir; he is returning to Holland.'

'To Holland!' cried D'Arragnan; 'and I?'

'You are at liberty to follow him, monsieur; but I request you to remain,' said Monk. 'Will you refuse me?'

'Oh, no, general; I am at your orders.'

D'Arragnan embraced Athos, and only had time to bid him adieu. Monk watched them both. Then he took upon himself the preparations for the departure, the transportation of the casks on board, and the embarking of Athos; then, taking D'Arragnan by the arm, who was quite amazed and agitated, he led him towards Newcastle. Whilst going along, the general leaning on his arm, D'Arragnan could not help murmuring to himself,—'Come, come, it seems to me that the shares of the firm of Planchet and Company are rising.'

his house under pretence of taking him to the camp; but he, without being frightened by their number, threatened death to the first who should cross the threshold of his door; and as there was one who did venture, the Frenchman stretched him on the earth with a pistol-shot.'

'Ah! he is a Frenchman, is he?' said D'Arragnan, rubbing his hands. 'Good!'

'How good?' replied the fisherman.

'No, I don't mean that.—What then—my tongue slipped.'

'What then, sir?—why, the other men became as enraged as so many lions: they fired more than a hundred shots at the house; but the Frenchman was sheltered by the wall, and every time they tried to enter by the door they met with a shot from his lackey, whose aim is deadly; d'ye see? Every time they threatened the window, they met with a pistol-shot from the master. Look and count—there are seven men down.'

'Ah! my brave countryman,' cried D'Arragnan, 'wait a little, wait a little. I will be with you; and we will settle with this rabble.'

'One instant, sir,' said Monk, 'wait.'

'Long?'

'No; only the time to ask a question.' Then, turning towards the sailor, 'My friend,' asked he, with an emotion which, in spite of all his self-command, he could not conceal, 'whose soldiers are these, pray tell me?'

'Whose should they be but that madman, Monk's?'

'There has been no battle, then?'

'A battle, ah, yes! for what purpose? Lambert's army is melting away like snow in April. All come to Monk, officers and soldiers. In a week Lambert won't have fifty men left.'

The fisherman was interrupted by a fresh discharge directed against the house, and by another pistol-shot which replied to the discharge and struck down the most daring of the aggressors. The rage of soldiers was at its height. The fire still continued to increase, and a crest of flame and smoke whirled and spread over the roof of the house. D'Arragnan could no longer contain himself. 'Mordieux!' said he to Monk, glancing at him sideways: 'you are a general, and allow your men to burn houses and assassinate people, while you look on and warm your hands at the blaze of the conflagration? Mordieux! you are not a man.'

'Patience, sir, patience!' said Monk, smiling.

followed Monk exactly as a chained bear follows his master; but the position humiliated him not a little, and he grumbled to himself that the service of kings was a bitter one, and that the best of them was good for nothing. Monk walked with long and hasty strides; it might be thought that he did not yet feel certain of having reached English land. They had already begun to perceive distinctly a few of the cottages of the sailors and fishermen spread over the little quay of this humble port, when, all at once, D'Artagnan cried out,—‘God pardon me, there is a house on fire!’

Monk raised his eyes, and perceived there was, in fact, a house which the flames were beginning to devour. It had begun at a little shed belonging to the house, the roof of which had caught. The fresh evening breeze agitated the fire. The two travellers quickened their steps, hearing loud cries, and seeing, as they drew nearer, soldiers with their glittering arms pointed towards the house on fire. It was doubtless this menacing occupation which had made them neglect to signal the felucca. Monk stopped short for an instant, and, for the first time, formulated his thoughts into words. ‘Eh! but,’ said he, ‘perhaps they are not my soldiers but Lambert’s.’

These words contained at once a sorrow, and apprehension, and a reproach perfectly intelligible to D'Artagnan. In fact, during the general's absence, Lambert might have given battle, conquered, and dispersed the parliament's army, and taken with his own the place of Monk's army, deprived of its strongest support. At this doubt, which passed from the mind of Monk to his own, D'Artagnan reasoned in this manner:—‘One of two things is going to happen; either Monk has spoken correctly, and there are no longer any but Lambertists in the country—that is to say, enemies, who would receive me wonderfully well, since it is to me they owe their victory; or nothing is changed, and Monk, transported with joy at finding his camp still in the same place, will not prove too severe in his settlement with me.’ Whilst thinking thus, the two travellers advanced, and began to mingle with a little knot of sailors, who looked on with sorrow at the burning house, but did not dare to say anything on account of the threats of the soldiers. Monk addressed one of these sailors:—‘What is going on here?’ asked he.

‘Sir,’ replied the man, not recognizing Monk as an officer, under the thick cloak which enveloped him, ‘that house was inhabited by a foreign gentleman, and this foreigner became suspected by the soldiers. They wanted to get into

Chapter XXXI

Monk reveals Himself



D'ARTAGNAN, although he flattered himself with better success, had, nevertheless, not too well comprehended his situation. It was a strange and grave subject for him to reflect upon—this voyage of Athos into England; this league of the king with Athos, and that extraordinary combination of his design with that of the Comte de la Fère. The best way was to let things follow their own train. An imprudence had been committed, and, whilst having succeeded, as he had promised, D'Artagnan found that he had gained no advantage by his success. Since everything was lost, he could risk no more.

D'Artagnan followed Monk through his camp. The return of the general had produced a marvellous effect, for his people had thought him lost. But Monk, with his austere look and icy demeanour, appeared to ask of his eager lieutenants and delighted soldiers the cause of all this joy. Therefore, to the lieutenants who had come to meet him, and who expressed the uneasiness with which they had learnt his departure,—

‘Why is all this?’ said he; ‘am I obliged to give you an account of myself?’

‘But your honour, the sheep may well tremble without the shepherd.’

‘Tremble!’ replied Monk, in his calm and powerful voice; ‘ah, monsieur, what a word! Curse me, if my sheep have not both teeth and claws; I renounce being their shepherd. Ah, you tremble, gentlemen, do you?’

‘Yes, general, for you.’

‘Oh! pray meddle with your own concerns. If I have not the wit God gave to Oliver Cromwell, I have that which He has sent to me: I am satisfied with it, however little it may be.’

The officer made no reply; and Monk, having imposed silence on his people, all remained persuaded that he had accomplished some important work or made some important trial. This was forming a very poor conception of his patience and scrupulous genius. Monk, if he had the good faith of the Puritans, his allies, must have returned fervent thanks to the patron saint who had taken him from the box of M. d'Artagnan. Whilst these things were going on, our musketeer could not help constantly repeating,—

‘God grant that M. Monk may not have as much pride as I have; for I declare that if any one had put me into a coffer with that grating over my mouth, and carried me packed up, like a calf, across the seas, I should cherish such a memory of my piteous looks in that coffer, and such an ugly animosity against him who had inclosed me in it, I should dread so greatly to see a sarcastic smile blooming upon the face of the malicious wretch, or in his attitude any grotesque imitation of my position in the box, that, Mordieux! I should plunge a good dagger into his throat in compensation for the grating, and would nail him down in a veritable bier, in remembrance of the false coffin in which I had been left in to grow mouldy for two days.’

And D'Artagnan spoke honestly when he spoke thus; for the skin of our Gascon was a very thin one. Monk, fortunately, entertained other ideas. He never opened his mouth to his timid conqueror concerning the past; but he admitted him very near to his person in his labours, took him with him to several reconnoiterings, in such a way as to obtain that which he evidently warmly desired,—a rehabilitation in the mind of D'Artagnan. The latter conducted himself like a past-master in the art of flattery: he admired all Monk's tactics, and the ordering of his camp; he joked very pleasantly upon the circumvallations of Lambert's camp, who had, he said, very uselessly given himself the trouble to inclose a camp for twenty thousand men, whilst an acre of ground would have been quite sufficient for the corporal and fifty guards who would perhaps remain faithful to him.

Monk, immediately after his arrival, had accepted the proposition made by Lambert the evening before, for an interview, and which Monk's lieutenants had refused under the pretext that the general was indisposed. This interview was neither long nor interesting; Lambert demanded a profession of faith from his rival. The latter declared he had no other opinion than that of the majority. Lambert asked if it would not be more expedient to terminate the quarrel

Chapter XXX

The Shares of Planchet and Company rise again to Par



URING the passage, Monk only spoke to D'Artagnan in cases of urgent necessity. Thus, when the Frenchman hesitated to come and take his meals, poor meals, composed of salt fish, biscuit, and Hollands gin, Monk called him, saying,—‘To table, monsieur, to table!’

This was all. D'Artagnan, from being himself on all great occasions, extremely concise, did not draw from the general's conciseness a favourable augury of the result of his mission. Now, as D'Artagnan had plenty of time for reflection, he battered his brains during this time in endeavouring to find out how Athos had seen King Charles, how he had conspired his departure with him, and lastly, how he had entered Monk's camp; and the poor lieutenant of musketeers plucked a hair from his moustache every time that he reflected that the horseman who accompanied Monk on the night of the famous abduction must have been Athos.

At length, after a passage of two nights and two days, the patron Keyser touched at the point where Monk, who had given all the orders during the voyage, had commanded they should land. It was exactly at the mouth of the little river, near where Athos had chosen his abode.

Daylight was waning, a splendid sun, like a red steel buckler, was plunging the lower extremity of its disc beneath the blue line of the sea. The felucca was making fair way up the river, tolerably wide in that part, but Monk, in his impatience, desired to be landed, and Keyser's boat set him and D'Artagnan upon the muddy bank, amidst the reeds. D'Artagnan, resigned to obedience,

monsieur le chevalier,' said he, 'thanks for your services. They will be repaid you by the Lord God, who, I hope, reserves trials and troubles for me alone.'

Monk followed Keyser and his son embarked with them. D'Artagnan came after, muttering to himself,—'Poor Planchet! poor Planchet! I am very much afraid we have made a bad speculation.'

by an alliance than by a battle. Monk hereupon demanded a week for consideration. Now, Lambert could not refuse this: and Lambert, nevertheless, had come saying that he should devour Monk's army. Therefore, at the end of the interview, which Lambert's party watched with impatience, nothing was decided—neither treaty nor battle—the rebel army, as M. d'Artagnan had foreseen, began to prefer the good cause to the bad one, and the parliament, rumpish as it was, to the pompous nothings of Lambert's designs.

They remembered, likewise, the good feasts of London—the profusion of ale and sherry with which the citizens of London paid their friends the soldiers;—they looked with terror at the black war bread, at the troubled waters of the Tweed,—too salt for the glass, not enough so for the pot; and they said to themselves, 'Are not the roast meats kept warm for Monk in London?' From that time nothing was heard of but desertion in Lambert's army. The soldiers allowed themselves to be drawn away by the force of principles, which are, like discipline, the obligatory tie in everybody constituted for any purpose. Monk defended the parliament—Lambert attacked it. Monk had no more inclination to support parliament than Lambert, but he had it inscribed on his standards, so that all those of the contrary party were reduced to write upon theirs, 'Rebellion,' which sounded ill to puritan ears. They flocked, then, from Lambert to Monk, as sinners flock from Baal to God.

Monk made his calculations; at a thousand desertions a day Lambert had men enough to last twenty days; but there is in sinking things such a growth of weight and swiftness, which combine with each other, that a hundred left the first day, five hundred the second, a thousand the third. Monk thought he had obtained his rate. But from one thousand the deserters increased to two thousand, then to four thousand, and, a week after, Lambert, perceiving that he had no longer the possibility of accepting battle, if it were offered to him, took the wise resolution of decamping during the night, returning to London, and being beforehand with Monk in constructing a power with the wreck of the military party.

But Monk, free and without uneasiness, marched towards London as a conqueror, augmenting his army with all the floating parties on the way. He encamped at Barne, that is to say, within four leagues of the capital, cherished by the parliament, which thought it beheld in him a protector, and awaited by the people, who were anxious to see him reveal himself, that they might judge

him. D'Artagnan himself had not been able to fathom his ractics; he observed—he admired. Monk could not enter London with a settled determination without bringing about civil war. He temporized for a short time.

Suddenly, when least expected, Monk drove the military party out of London, and installed himself in the city amidst the citizens, by order of the parliament; then, at the moment when the citizens were crying out against Monk—at the moment when the soldiers themselves were accusing their leader—Monk, finding himself certain of a majority, declared to the Rump Parliament that it must abdicate—be dissolved—and yield its place to a government which would not be a joke. Monk pronounced this declaration, supported by fifty thousand swords, to which, that same evening, were united, with shouts of delirious joy, the five thousand inhabitants of the good city of London. At length, at the moment when the people, after their triumphs and festive repasts in the open streets, were looking about for a master, it was affirmed that a vessel had left the Hague, bearing King Charles II and his fortunes.

'Gentlemen,' said Monk to his officers, 'I am going to meet the legitimate king. He who loves me will follow me.' A burst of acclamations welcomed these words, which D'Artagnan did not hear without the greatest delight.

'Mordieux!' said he to Monk, 'that is bold, monsieur.'

'You will accompany me, will you not?' said Monk.

'Pardieu! general. But tell me, I beg, what you wrote by Athos, that is to say, the Comte de la Fère—you know—the day of our arrival?'

'I have no secrets from you now,' replied Monk. 'I wrote these words: "Sire, I expect your majesty in six weeks at Dover."'

'Ah!' said D'Artagnan, 'I no longer say it is bold; I say it is well played; it is a fine stroke!'

'You are something of a judge in such matters,' replied Monk.

And this was the only time the general had ever made an allusion to his voyage to Holland.

'Well, is all arranged?' asked the king, drawing near.

'All but the price,' said the fisherman; 'yes, sire.'

'That is my affair,' said Charles, 'the gentleman is my friend.'

Monk started and looked at Charles on hearing this word.

'Very well, my lord,' replied Keyser. And at that moment they heard Keyser's son, signaling from the shore with the blast of a bull's horn.

'Now, gentlemen,' said the king, 'depart.'

'Sire,' said D'Artagnan, 'will it please your majesty to grant me a few minutes? I have engaged men, and I am going without them; I must give them notice.'

'Whistle to them,' said Charles, smiling.

D'Artagnan, accordingly, whistled, whilst the patron Keyser replied to his son; and four men, led by Menneville, attended the first summons.

'Here is some money in account,' said D'Artagnan, putting into their hands a purse containing two thousand five hundred livres in gold. 'Go and wait for me at Calais, you know where.' And D'Artagnan heaved a profound sigh, as he let the purse fall into the hands of Menneville.

'What, are you leaving us?' cried the men.

'For a short time,' said D'Artagnan, 'or for a long time, who knows? But with 2,500 livres, and the 2,500 you have already received, you are paid according to our agreement. We are quits, then, my friend.'

'But the boat?'

'Do not trouble yourself about that.'

'Our things are on board the felucca.'

'Go and seek them, and then set off immediately.'

'Yes, captain.'

D'Artagnan returned to Monk, saying,—'Monsieur, I await your orders, for I understand we are to go together, unless my company be disagreeable to you.'

'On the contrary, monsieur,' said Monk.

'Come, gentlemen, on board,' cried Keyser's son.

Charles bowed to the general with grace and dignity, saying,—'You will pardon me this unfortunate accident, and the violence to which you have been subjected, when you are convinced that I was not the cause of them.'

Monk bowed profoundly without replying. On his side, Charles affected not to say a word to D'Artagnan in private, but aloud,—'Once more, thanks,

hand beneath his cloak. Monk followed him, with crossed arms and an uneasy look. D'Artagnan came last, with his hand on the hilt of his sword.

'Where is the boat in which you came, gentlemen?' said Charles to the musketeer.

'Yonder, sire; I have seven men and an officer waiting me in that little bark which is lighted by a fire.'

'Yes, I see; the boat is drawn upon the sand; but you certainly did not come from Newcastle in that frail bark?'

'No, sire; I freighted a felucca, at my own expense, which is at anchor within cannon-shot of the downs. It was in that felucca we made the voyage.'

'Sir,' said the king to Monk, 'you are free.'

However firm his will, Monk could not suppress an exclamation. The king added an affirmative motion of his head, and continued: 'We shall waken a fisherman of the village, who will put his boat to sea immediately, and will take you back to any place you may command him. M. d'Artagnan here will escort your honour. I place M. d'Artagnan under the safeguard of your loyalty, M. Monk.'

Monk allowed a murmur of surprise to escape him, and D'Artagnan a profound sigh. The king, without appearing to notice either, knocked against the deal trellis which inclosed the cabin of the principal fisherman inhabiting the down.

'Hey! Keyser!' cried he, 'awake!'

'Who calls me?' asked the fisherman.

'I, Charles the king.'

'Ah, my lord!' cried Keyser, rising ready dressed from the sail in which he slept, as people sleep in a hammock. 'What can I do to serve you?'

'Captain Keyser,' said Charles, 'you must set sail immediately. Here is a traveller who wishes to freight your bark, and will pay you well; serve him well.'

And the king drew back a few steps to allow Monk to speak to the fisherman.

'I wish to cross over into England,' said Monk, who spoke Dutch enough to make himself understood.

'This minute,' said the patron, 'this very minute, if you wish it.'

'But will that be long?' said Monk.

'Not half an hour, your honour. My eldest son is at this moment preparing the boat, as we were going out fishing at three o'clock in the morning.'

Chapter XXXII

Athos and D'Artagnan Meet Once More at the Hostelry of the Corne du Cerf



THE king of England made his entrée into Dover with great pomp, as he afterwards did in London. He had sent for his brothers; he had brought over his mother and sister. England had been for so long a time given up to herself—that is to say, to tyranny, mediocrity and nonsense—that this return of Charles II, whom the English only knew as the son of the man whose head they had cut off, was a festival for three kingdoms. Consequently, all the good wishes, all the acclamations which accompanied his return, struck the young king so forcibly that he stooped and whispered in the ear of James of York, his younger brother, 'In truth, James, it seems to have been our own fault that we were so long absent from a country where we are so much beloved!' The pa-
geant was magnificent. Beautiful weather favoured the solemnity. Charles had regained all his youth, all his good humour; he appeared to be transfigured; hearts seemed to smile on him like the sun. Amongst this noisy crowd of courtiers and worshippers, who did not appear to remember they had conducted to the scaffold at Whitehall the father of the new king, a man, in the garb of a lieutenant of musketeers, looked, with a smile upon his thin, intellectual lips, sometimes at the people vociferating their blessings, and sometimes at the prince, who pretended emotion, and who bowed most particularly to the women, whose bouquets fell beneath his horse's feet.

‘What a fine trade is that of king!’ said this man, so completely absorbed in contemplation that he stopped in the middle of the road, leaving the cortège to file past. ‘Now, there is, in good truth, a prince all bespangled over with gold and diamonds, enamelled with flowers like a spring meadow; he is about to plunge his empty hands into the immense coffer in which his now faithful—but so lately unfaithful—subjects have amassed one or two cartloads of ingots of gold. They cast bouquets enough upon him to smother him; and yet, if he had presented himself to them two months ago, they would have sent as many bullets and balls at him as they now throw flowers. Decidedly it is worth something to be born in a certain sphere, with due respect to the lowly, who pretend that it is of very little advantage to them to be born lowly.’ The cortège continued to file on, and, with the king, the acclamations began to die away in the direction of the palace, which, however, did not prevent our officer from being pushed about.

‘Mordieux!’ continued the reasoner, ‘these people tread upon my toes and look upon me as of very little consequence, or rather of none at all, seeing that they are Englishmen and I am a Frenchman. If all these people were asked,—“Who is M. d’Arragnan?” they would reply, “Nescio vos.” But let any one say to them, “There is the king going by,” “There is M. Monk going by,” they would run away, shouting,—“Vive le roi!” “Vive M. Monk!” till their lungs were exhausted. And yet,’ continued he, surveying, with that look sometimes so keen and sometimes so proud, the diminishing crowd,—‘and yet, reflect a little, my good people, on what your king has done, on what M. Monk has done, and then think what has been done by this poor unknown, who is called M. d’Arragnan! It is true you do not know him, since he is here unknown, and that prevents your thinking about the matter! But, bah! what matters it! All that does not prevent Charles II from being a great king, although he has been exiled twelve years, or M. Monk from being a great captain, although he did make a voyage to Holland in a box. Well, then, since it is admitted that one is a great king and the other a great captain,—“Hurrah for King Charles III!—Hurrah for General Monk!” And his voice mingled with the voices of the hundreds of spectators, over which it sounded for a moment. Then, the better to play the devoted man, he took off his hat and waved it in the air. Some one seized his arm in the very height of his expansive loyalty. (In 1660 that was so termed which we now call royalism.)

‘Then, Monsieur d’Arragnan,’ continued Charles, ‘this is what was about to happen: M. le Comte de la Fère, who you know, I believe, has set out for Newcastle.’

‘What, Athos!’ exclaimed D’Arragnan.

‘Yes, that was his nom de guerre, I believe. The Comte de la Fère had then set out for Newcastle, and was going, perhaps, to bring the general to hold a conference with me or with those of my party, when you violently, as it appears, interfered with the negotiation.’

‘Mordieux!’ replied D’Arragnan, ‘he entered the camp the very evening in which I succeeded in getting into it with my fishermen—’,

An almost imperceptible frown on the brow of Monk told D’Arragnan that he had surmised rightly.

‘Yes, yes,’ muttered he; ‘I thought I knew his person; I even fancied I knew his voice. Unlucky wretch that I am! Oh! sire, pardon me! I thought I had so successfully steered my bark.’

‘There is nothing ill in it, sir,’ said the king, ‘except that the general accuses me of having laid a snare for him, which is not the case. No, general, those are not the arms which I contemplated employing with you, as you will soon see. In the meanwhile, when I give you my word upon the honour of a gentleman, believe me, sir, believe me! Now, Monsieur d’Arragnan, a word with you, if you please.’

‘I listen on my knees, sire.’

‘You are truly at my service, are you not?’

‘Your majesty has seen that I am, too much so.’

‘That is well; from a man like you one word suffices. In addition to that word you bring actions. General, have the goodness to follow me. Come with us, M. d’Arragnan.’

D’Arragnan, considerably surprised, prepared to obey. Charles II went out, Monk followed him, D’Arragnan followed Monk. Charles took the path by which D’Arragnan had come to his abode; the fresh sea breezes soon caressed the faces of the three nocturnal travelers, and, at fifty paces from the little gate which Charles opened, they found themselves upon the down in the face of the ocean, which, having ceased to rise, reposed upon the shore like a wearied monster. Charles II walked pensively along, his head hanging down and his

at in so considerable a man, the wound in whose mind must at the moment have been cruel. Charles II formed, on the instant, one of those resolutions upon which an ordinary man risks his life, a general his fortune, and a king his kingdom. 'Monseigneur,' said he to Monk, 'you are perfectly right upon certain points; I do not, therefore, ask you to answer me, but to listen to me.'

There was a moment's silence, during which the king looked at Monk, who remained impassible.

'You have made me just now a painful reproach, monseigneur,' continued the king; 'you said that one of my emissaries had been to Newcastle to lay a snare for you, and that, parenthetically, cannot be understood by M. d'Artagnan here, and to whom, before everything, I owe sincere thanks for his generous, his heroic devotion.'

D'Artagnan bowed with respect; Monk took no notice.

'For M. d'Artagnan—and observe, M. Monk, I do not say this to excuse myself—for M. d'Artagnan,' continued the king, 'went to England of his free will, without interest, without orders, without hope, like a true gentleman as he is, to render a service to an unfortunate king, and to add to the illustrious actions of an existence, already so well filled, one glorious deed more.'

D'Artagnan coloured a little, and coughed to keep his countenance. Monk did not stir.

'You do not believe what I tell you, M. Monk,' continued the king. 'I can understand that,—such proofs of devotion are so rare, that their reality may well be put in doubt.'

'Monseigneur would do wrong not to believe you, sire,' cried D'Artagnan: 'for that which your majesty has said is the exact truth, and the truth so exact that it seems, in going to fetch the general, I have done something which sets everything wrong. In truth, if it be so, I am in despair.'

'Monseigneur d'Artagnan,' said the king, pressing the hand of the musketeer, 'you have obliged me as much as if you had promoted the success of my cause, for you have revealed to me an unknown friend, to whom I shall ever be grateful, and whom I shall always love.' And the king pressed his hand cordially. 'And,' continued he, bowing to Monk, 'an enemy whom I shall henceforth esteem at his proper value.'

The eyes of the Puritan flashed, but only once, and his countenance, for an instant, illuminated by that flash, resumed its somber impassibility.

'Athos!' cried D'Artagnan, 'you here!' And the two friends seized each other's hands.

'You here!—and being here,' continued the musketeer, 'you are not in the midst of all these courtiers, my dear comel! What! you, the hero of the fete, you are not prancing on the left hand of the king, as M. Monk is prancing on the right? In truth, I cannot comprehend your character, nor that of the prince who owes you so much!'

'Always scornful, my dear D'Artagnan!' said Athos. 'Will you never correct yourself of that vile habit?'

'But you do not form part of the pageant?'

'I do not, because I was not willing to do so.'

'And why were you not willing?'

'Because I am neither envoy nor ambassador, nor representative of the king of France; and it does not become me to exhibit myself thus near the person of another king than the one God has given me for a master.'

'Mordionx! you came very near to the person of the king, his father.'

'That was another thing, my friend; he was about to die.'

'And yet that which you did for him—'

'I did it because it was my duty to do it. But you know I hate all ostentation. Let King Charles II, then, who no longer stands in need of me, leave me to my rest, and the shadow; that is all I claim of him.'

D'Artagnan sighed.

'What is the matter with you?' said Athos. 'One would say that this happy return of the king to London saddens you, my friend; you who have done at least as much for his majesty as I have.'

'Have I not,' replied D'Artagnan, with his Gascon laugh, 'have I not done much for his majesty, without any one suspecting it?'

'Yes, yes, but the king is well aware of it, my friend,' cried Athos.

'He is aware of it!' said the musketeer bitterly. 'By my faith! I did not suspect so, and I was even a moment ago trying to forget it myself.'

'But he, my friend, will not forget it, I will answer for him.'

'You tell me that to console me a little, Athos.'

'For what?'

‘Mordiouxi for all the expense I incurred. I have ruined myself, my friend, ruined myself for the restoration of this young prince who has just passed, cantering on his isabella coloured horse.’

‘The king does not know you have ruined yourself, my friend; but he knows he owes you much.’

‘And say, Athos, does that advance me in any respect? for, to do you justice, you have laboured nobly. But I—I who in appearance marred your combinations, it was I who really made them succeed. Follow my calculations closely; you might not have, by persuasions or mildness, convinced General Monk, whilst I so roughly treated this dear general, that I furnished your prince with an opportunity of showing himself generous: this generosity was inspired in him by the fact of my fortunate mistake, and Charles is paid by the restoration which Monk has brought about.’

‘All that, my dear friend, is strikingly true,’ replied Athos.

‘Well, strikingly true as it may be, it is not less true, my friend, that I shall return—greatly beloved by M. Monk, who calls me dear captain all day long, although I am neither dear to him nor a captain;—and much appreciated by the king, who has already forgotten my name;—it is not less true, I say, that I shall return to my beautiful country, cursed by the soldiers I had raised with the hopes of large pay, cursed by the brave Planchet, of who I have borrowed a part of his fortune.’

‘How is that? What the devil had Planchet to do in all this?’

‘Ah, yes, my friend; but this king, so spruce, so smiling, so adored, M. Monk fancies he has recalled him, you fancy you have supported him, I fancy I have brought him back, the people fancy they have reconquered him, he himself fancies he has negotiated his restoration; and yet nothing of all this is true, for Charles II, king of England, Scotland, and Ireland, has been replaced upon the throne by a French grocer, who lives in the Rue des Lombards, and is named Planchet. And such is grandeur! “Vanity!” says the Scripture: “Vanity, all is vanity.”’

Athos could not help laughing at this whimsical outbreak of his friend.

‘My dear D’Artagnan,’ said he, pressing his hand affectionately, ‘should you not exercise a little more philosophy? Is it not some further satisfaction to you to have saved my life as you did by arriving so fortunately with Monk, when those damned parliamentarians wanted to burn me alive?’

prisoner, ‘you are in the presence of his majesty Charles II, sovereign lord of Great Britain.’

Monk raised towards the prince his coldly stoical look, and replied: ‘I know no king of Great Britain; I recognize even here no one worthy of bearing the name of gentleman: for it is in the name of King Charles II that an emissary, whom I took for an honest man, came and laid an infamous snare for me. I have fallen into that snare; so much the worse for me. Now, you the tempter,’ said he to the king; ‘you the executor,’ said he to D’Artagnan; ‘remember what I am about to say to you: you have my body, you may kill it, and I advise you to do so, for you shall never have my mind or my will. And now, ask me not a single word, as from this moment I will not open my mouth even to cry out. I have said.’

And he pronounced these words with the savage, invincible resolution of the most mortified Puritan. D’Artagnan looked at his prisoner like a man who knows the value of every word, and who fixes that value according to the accent with which it has been pronounced.

‘The fact is,’ said he, in a whisper to the king, ‘the general is an obstinate man; he would not take a mouthful of bread, nor swallow a drop of wine, during the two days of our voyage. But as from this moment it is your majesty who must decide his fate, I wash my hands of him.’

Monk, erect, pale, and resigned, waited with his eyes fixed and his arms folded. D’Artagnan turned towards him. ‘You will please to understand perfectly,’ said he, ‘that your speech, otherwise very fine, does not suit anybody, not even yourself. His majesty wished to speak to you, you refused an interview; why, now that you are face to face, that you are here by a force independent of your will, why do you confine yourself to the rigors which I consider useless and absurd? Speak! what the devil! speak, if only to say “No.”’

Monk did not uncloset his lips; Monk did not turn his eyes; Monk stroked his moustache with a thoughtful air, which announced that matters were going on badly.

During all this time Charles II had fallen into a profound reverie. For the first time he found himself face to face with Monk; with the man he had so much desired to see; and, with that peculiar glance which God has given to eagles and kings, he had fathomed the abyss of his heart. He beheld Monk, then, resolved positively to die rather than speak, which was not to be wondered